GMAT RC Passage Map Template

3-Pass Structural Reading, Structural Pivot Keywords & Question Archetype Battlecard

1. The Structural Reading Framework: Read for Purpose, Not Details

GMAT Reading Comprehension passages test big-picture logical architecture, author intent, and argument flow—not memorization.

Passage Component	What to Read For	Shorthand Scratchpad Note	Time Investment Budget
Paragraph 1 (The Hook & Thesis)	Identify topic, conventional wisdom, and whether author introduces a new theory	P1: Old theory X (flawed)	60 – 75 Seconds
Paragraph 2 (Evidence / Turn)	Look for pivot words (However, Yet, In contrast); trace counter-evidence	P2: New study Y shows counter-evidence	45 – 60 Seconds
Paragraph 3 (Resolution / Caveat)	Evaluate author's final stance: enthusiastic, critical, cautious, neutral	P3: Author favors Y with caveats	30 – 45 Seconds
Whole Passage Shorthand Map	Synthesize Primary Purpose: Explain, Challenge, Reconcile, or Advocate	Map: Challenge X using Y, support with limits	Total Read: Under 3.5 Mins

Rule: Never spend more than 3.5 minutes reading any RC passage, regardless of length or technical density.

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2. Structural Pivot Keyword Signals & Authorial Tone

Train your eyes to spot transition signposts that dictate shifts in argument structure.

Keyword Category	Signal Words to Circle	Structural Function in Passage	Anticipated Question Type
Contradiction & Shift	However, Nevertheless, On the contrary, Yet, Despite	Author is overturning previous theory or presenting counterpoint	Primary Purpose / Main Idea question
Evidence & Elaboration	Furthermore, Moreover, In addition, For instance, Because	Providing supporting data for the current assertion; skim quickly	Detail / "According to the passage" question
Concession & Nuance	Granted, Admittedly, Although, While it is true that	Author concedes a minor point to opponent before rebuttal	Author's Tone / Perspective question
Causal Conclusion	Therefore, Consequently, As a result, Thus, Hence	Marking the core intellectual takeaway or recommendation	Inference / Logical Extension question

Speed Tip: Skim dense scientific lists and names; you can always return to them when a detail question cites them.

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3. RC Question Archetypes & Elimination Protocols

Proven methods to tackle the 3 primary question varieties in GMAT Focus RC.

- Main Idea / Primary Purpose Questions: Answer must encompass the entire passage. Reject choices that focus on only one paragraph or use biased words not supported by the author.
- Inference Questions ("The passage suggests...", "It can be inferred that..."): The correct answer is 100% provable from passage statements, often by negating a stated boundary. Never speculate.
- Detail / Retrieval Questions ("According to the author..."): Return directly to the text using your passage map; verify the exact phrasing and eliminate choices that twist facts.
- Review Habit: Always analyze why the wrong answers are wrong (too narrow, too broad, distorted tone, out of scope).